

Why Does It Still Hurt?

Forgiveness and the slow return of trust.

סליחה

selichah · seh-lee-CHAH · forgiveness

FOUR COMMENTARIES ON ONE VERSE

SFORNO

The father he has lost

When they recalled his father and his love, for [his father] had not suspected him.

[Genesis 50:17, full comment](#)

BERESHIT RABBAH

A missed invitation

Rabbi Levi said that he no longer invited them to a meal. Rabbi Tanchuma said: His intention was only for the sake of Heaven. He said, “In the past, Father seated me above Judah, who is king, and Reuben, who is firstborn. Now it is not right for me to sit above them.” But they did not see it that way: “Perhaps Joseph hates us.”

[100:8, first interpretation](#)

[Genesis 50:17](#)

וַיִּבְךְּ יוֹסֵף
בְּדַבָּרָם אֵלָיו

*“When their message
came to him, Joseph
wept.”*

NIV · excerpt

*Can you forgive someone and
still feel the hurt?*

JONATHAN SACKS

Still afraid of him

Yet still, all these years later, his brothers do not trust him and fear that he may still seek their harm.

[The Last Tears, excerpt](#)

RABBEINU BAHYA

Did he ever forgive?

His brothers asked his forgiveness, but Scripture does not explain that he forgave them. ... Although Scripture says, “He comforted them and spoke to their hearts,” which seems to indicate that Joseph was reconciled with them, we do not see Scripture mention Joseph’s forgiveness.

[Genesis 50:17, excerpt](#)

An apology is a beginning

READING THE SCENE

You accepted the apology. Then a short reply brings the old hurt back. You thought you had moved past it. Why does something so small still matter?

Joseph has welcomed his brothers and provided for them. Yet after their father dies, they fear revenge and ask forgiveness. Joseph weeps. Sforzo hears grief for a father who trusted him. Jonathan Sacks sees the pain of brothers who still do not.

The midrash imagines a missed invitation. Joseph changes the family meal out of respect for his brothers. They read the change as rejection. Old fear makes an innocent gesture frightening. This is the rabbis' interpretation, not an event Genesis describes.

Rabbeinu Bahya concludes that Joseph never forgave them. Sacks understands Joseph as having made peace with them, yet unable to win their trust. Caring for someone, offering forgiveness, and feeling close again may be different things. I hear a patient lesson here: lingering hurt deserves attention, too.

Selichah means forgiveness. Here the brothers use *sa na*, "please forgive," from *nasa*, to lift, carry, or forgive. It is a different Hebrew root.

A PRACTICE FROM JEWISH TRADITION

Say what still hurts

"When one person wrongs another, the injured person should not hate him and remain silent. ... Rather, he is commanded to tell him: 'Why did you do this to me?'"

Maimonides · [Human Dispositions 6:6](#) · Working translation from Hebrew

For an ordinary strain in a relationship you want to repair, try completing this sentence: "What I still need you to understand is..." Then name one action that would help trust return. Leave room to listen.

READ AND DISCUSS

1. Why might Joseph cry even after choosing to care for his brothers?
 2. How does the missed invitation change your reading of the brothers' fear?
 3. What would help you distinguish forgiveness from restored trust?
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FURTHER READING

Rabbi Jonathan Sacks · [The Last Tears](#)

Free essay · Joseph's tears and the limits of power.

Lawrence Kushner and Kerry M. Olitzky · [Sparks Beneath the Surface](#)

Book · "Teshuvah as Rewriting the Past," pp. 55-56.